

Letters I Never Sent

A Novel

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Chapter 1 — The Discovery

The rain came suddenly over Kampala, as it always did in November.

Amina Kintu dashed through the narrow alley behind Kampala Road, her notebook held over her head in a futile gesture against the downpour. The red dust of the city streets had turned to mud within minutes, splattering the hem of her navy blue dress. She cursed under her breath — not at the rain, but at herself. She should have known better. In Kampala, November afternoons were never dry.

She ducked into the first doorway she found, pressing herself against the weathered wooden frame as the rain hammered against the corrugated iron roof above. The air smelled of wet earth and decay, that particular Kampala scent that clung to everything during the rainy season.

It took her a moment to realize where she had taken shelter. The sign above the door, faded and barely legible, read: **MUKASA'S BOOKS & CURIOSITIES — EST. 1972.**

Amina had passed this shop a hundred times on her way to work at the Kampala Chronicle but had never once stepped inside. It was the kind of place that seemed to exist in a different time — a relic from an older Kampala, before the shopping malls and the coffee chains, before the city had decided to become modern.

The door creaked open at her touch.

Inside, the shop was a cathedral of forgotten things. Bookshelves rose to the ceiling, crammed with volumes of every size and color. Dust motes danced in the thin light that filtered through a single grimy window. The air was thick with the smell of old paper,

mold, and something else — something like incense, or maybe just the accumulated scent of decades.

"Welcome, welcome!"

The voice came from behind a mountainous desk piled high with papers. An old man peered over the stacks, his face weathered and kind, his eyes bright behind thick glasses.

"Sorry for barging in," Amina said, shaking water from her arms. "The rain — "

"Ah, the rain!" The old man chuckled, waving a hand. "She is a familiar visitor, no? Come in, come in. Dry yourself. I am Mukasa."

"Amina." She stepped further into the shop, her eyes adjusting to the dim light. "I've never been here before. I've walked past so many times..."

"Many people walk past." Mukasa shrugged, but there was no bitterness in it. "This shop, she is not for people in a hurry. She is for people who are... lost. Or looking for something they did not know they needed."

Amina smiled politely, already scanning the shelves. She was always scanning — it was the journalist in her, the habit of looking for stories in

unexpected places. The shop was a chaos of organization, books stacked on books, postcards tucked between volumes, small carvings and curiosities occupying every available surface.

She wandered deeper into the shop, letting her fingers trail across the spines of books. There were novels from the 1960s, textbooks from Makerere University, old atlases with maps of countries that no longer existed. A section devoted to poetry sat next to a collection of motorcycle repair manuals.

Near the back of the shop, behind a stack of National Geographic magazines from the 1980s, she found a box.

It was wooden, about the size of a shoebox, dark with age. A simple brass latch held it closed. It sat on a low shelf as if waiting for her.

"What is this?" she asked, pulling it out carefully.

Mukasa looked up from his papers. "Ah, that. I do not remember. Some things, they come with the estate sales. I buy whole collections, you know. Families sell everything after someone passes. I sort through later, when I have time."

Amina worked the latch. It opened with a small protest.

Inside, there were letters.

Dozens of them, tied together with faded red ribbon. The paper was yellowed and brittle at the edges. She lifted one out carefully, handling it as if it were spun glass.

The handwriting was beautiful — flowing, elegant, clearly written with care. The ink had faded to a gentle brown.

She unfolded the first letter.

My Dearest M,

I am writing this letter knowing I will never send it. That is the strange thing about love, is it not? We carry these words inside us, these confessions, these declarations, and they grow heavy. They demand to be set free. And so I write them down, even if no eyes but mine will ever read them.

I saw you today in the market. You were buying tomatoes from the woman near the corner, the one who always argues about the price but gives you extra

anyway because she likes your smile. You wore a yellow dress. You always look beautiful, but in yellow you look like sunshine, like the promise of a good day.

I wanted to walk up to you. I wanted to say something — anything. But what does a man like me say to a woman like you? I am a painter of empty canvases, a dreamer with no dreams worth sharing. You are the kind of woman who lights up rooms without trying.

So I watched from a distance, and I came home, and I wrote this letter that you will never read.

Perhaps that is for the best.

Yours, in silence, J

Amina read the letter twice. Her hands were trembling slightly. She looked at the date at the top — March 14, 1998.

Twenty years ago.

"Who wrote these?" she asked, her voice barely above a whisper.

Mukasa came around from behind his desk, moving slowly, his joints protesting. He took the letter from

her hands gently, holding it at arm's length to read it. His expression changed as he read — a softening, a sadness.

"I do not know," he said finally. "But whoever he was, he loved deeply. And he never told her."

Amina looked at the box, at the stack of letters bound in red ribbon. There had to be fifty of them, at least. Fifty letters, never sent. Fifty confessions of love that had never reached their intended recipient.

"How much for the box?" she asked.

Mukasa studied her for a long moment. "For you? Two thousand shillings."

She paid without bargaining. It was more than the box was worth, and she knew it. But as she stepped back out into the rain, which had softened to a drizzle, she felt like she was carrying something precious. Something fragile and important.

That evening, in her small apartment in Ntinda, Amina untied the red ribbon and spread the letters across her bed. She counted them — forty-seven letters in total, spanning from March 1998 to December 2001.

She poured herself a cup of tea, sat cross-legged on her bed, and began to read.

Chapter 2 — The First Reader

April 2, 1998

My Dearest M,

I have started painting again. For months, my studio has been full of blank canvases, empty and accusing. But yesterday, after seeing you at the café — the one near the university, where you sit by the window and write in your notebook — I came home and I could not stop.

I painted you. Not your face — I do not know your face well enough to capture it, though I have memorized every detail. I painted the way you held your pen, your fingers delicate and precise. I painted the way you tucked your hair behind your ear when you were thinking. I painted the light that fell across your table, golden and warm.

It is the best thing I have ever painted.

I have hung it on the wall opposite my bed. Now I wake up to you every morning. It is a strange comfort, loving someone who does not know you exist.

Yours, J

Amina set the letter down, a knot forming in her chest. She had been a journalist for six years. She had covered political upheavals, human tragedies, stories of triumph and despair. She had learned to keep a professional distance from the subjects of her reporting.

But these letters were different. They were not meant for her. She was an intruder, a voyeur, reading words that had been written for someone else's eyes — and had never reached even those.

She picked up the next letter.

May 17, 1998

My Dearest M,

Today I learned your name. Margaret.

I was at the café, as I so often am these days (I have become a regular, though I barely touch my coffee). A woman called to you from across the room — "Margaret! Over here!" — and you turned, and I saw your face fully for the first time.

Margaret.

It suits you. It is a strong name, a beautiful name. It sounds like the name of a woman who knows what she wants.

What I want is to introduce myself. What I want is to walk up to your table and say, "Hello, Margaret. My name is Joseph. I have been watching you for weeks, and I think I am falling in love with you."

But I am a coward. I know this now.

Instead, I will go home and paint. I will paint your smile, which I saw when you greeted your friend. I will paint the way your eyes crinkled at the corners. I will paint the sound of your laughter, which drifted across the room and settled somewhere in my chest, warm and permanent.

Yours, J

Joseph. His name was Joseph.

Amina looked at the date again. 1998. She would have been five years old then, living with her grandmother in Jinja while her parents worked in Kampala. She remembered nothing of that year — just a blur of childhood, of mango trees and school uniforms and the distant sound of the Nile.

But somewhere in this city, a painter named Joseph had been falling in love with a woman named Margaret. And he had never told her.

She read on.

June 3, 1998

My Dearest M—

I almost spoke to you today.

You dropped your notebook outside the café. I was walking behind you — not following, I promise, just walking in the same direction — and I saw it fall. I picked it up. I held it in my hands. Your notebook. The one you write in every day.

I could have said, "Excuse me, you dropped this." Such simple words. Four words. A child could say them.

But my throat closed up. My hands shook. I stood there like a fool, holding your notebook, watching you walk away. A man bumped into me and I dropped it again, and by the time I had picked it up, you were gone.

I brought it home. I did not mean to. I swear I did not mean to. But it was in my hands, and I could not let it go.

I have not opened it. I will not. It is yours, and I have already stolen too much — the sight of you, the sound of your voice, the image of your smile. I will not steal your words.

Tomorrow, I will return it. I will go to the café and wait for you, and I will give it back, and I will say, "I think this is yours." And maybe you will smile at me, and maybe we will talk, and maybe—

I am a fool.

J

Amina smiled despite herself. There was something endearing about this Joseph, this anonymous painter who could not bring himself to speak to the woman he loved. She knew the feeling — that paralysis in the presence of someone who mattered too much.

She glanced at the clock. It was past midnight. She had work in the morning, an interview with the Minister of Health about the new hospital funding. She should sleep.

Instead, she reached for the next letter.

Chapter 3 — Margaret

July 22, 1998

My Dearest Margaret,

I have decided to use your name. It feels less like a secret that way, less like I am hiding. I am still hiding, of course — I am writing a letter I will never send — but at least I can address you properly.

I returned your notebook. You were not at the café that day, or the next, or the next. I went every day for a week, your notebook in my bag, feeling like a criminal. On the seventh day, I saw you walking down the street with a man.

He was tall, handsome, well-dressed. He carried himself with confidence. He made you laugh — a real laugh, not the polite kind. And I knew.

Of course you had someone. Of course you did. A woman like you does not stay unclaimed for long.

I left the notebook at the café, with the owner. I told her to give it to you when you came in. I did not leave my name.

That night, I burned the painting of you. It felt wrong to keep it, knowing you belonged to someone else. The flames consumed your smile, your hands, your hair. I watched until there was nothing left but ash.

I told myself I would stop coming to the café. I told myself I would forget you.

I am a liar.

J

Amina felt a pang of sympathy. She knew that particular kind of heartbreak — the one that came not from loss, but from never having had at all. It was a strange grief, mourning the absence of something that had never existed.

She put the letter down and made herself a cup of tea, needing a moment to breathe. Her small kitchen was dark, the only light coming from the bulb above the stove. She could hear the distant sound of a matatu horn, the muffled bass of a neighbor's music.

When she returned to the letters, she chose one from deeper in the stack.

October 11, 1998

My Dearest Margaret,

I saw you at your wedding.

I did not mean to be there. I was walking past the cathedral — St. Mary's, in the city center — and I saw the cars, the flowers, the guests in their finery. I almost kept walking. But something made me stop. Something made me wait.

And then I saw you.

You were beautiful. Of course you were beautiful. You are always beautiful. But that day... you looked like happiness itself. Your dress was white and simple, and your hair was pinned up with little white flowers, and you were smiling in a way I had never seen before. A smile that reached your eyes, that transformed your face, that said: this is the happiest day of my life.

I watched you walk into the cathedral on your father's arm. I watched the doors close behind you.

I stood there for an hour, maybe two. I do not remember walking home. But I remember thinking: this is the end. This is the moment I stop hoping. This is the moment I let you go.

I have not painted since.

Yours, always, J

Amina wiped her eyes with the back of her hand. She was crying. She had not realized it until the tears reached her chin.

She had been a journalist for six years. She had learned to keep a professional distance from the subjects of her reporting. But these letters were different; they were pure emotion, distilled and preserved, a love that had existed only in words on paper and someone's hidden heart.

The wedding was at St. Mary's Cathedral. That was specific. That could be verified.

She checked the date again. October 11, 1998. St. Mary's Cathedral.

Amina reached for her laptop, fingers flying across the keyboard. She searched for wedding records, newspaper archives, anything that might tell her who Margaret was. But the Chronicle's digital archives only went back to 2005, and her searches yielded nothing.

She looked at the box of letters, then at the clock. It was nearly 2 AM.

She had an interview at 9 AM.

She closed the box, turned off the light, and lay in the dark, staring at the ceiling. But sleep did not come easily. Her mind was full of Joseph and Margaret, of unsent letters and unspoken love, of a story that had been waiting twenty years for someone to find it.

Chapter 4 — The Journalist's Instinct

The next morning, Amina was exhausted but wired.

She sat in the newsroom of the Kampala Chronicle, a sprawling open-plan office in a building on Jinja Road. The room hummed with the sound of typing, the chatter of reporters on phones, the occasional shout across the cubicles. Fans whirled overhead, doing battle with the heat.

Her interview with the Minister had gone well — smoothly, professionally, by the book. She had filed the story within an hour. Now she was staring at a blank screen, her fingers resting on the keyboard, her mind elsewhere.

"Amina! You look like you've seen a ghost."

She looked up. Daniel Wasswa was standing by her desk, coffee in hand, grinning. He was the Chronicle's senior features writer, a grizzled journalist in his late forties who had seen everything and retained his sense of humor.

"Didn't sleep well," she said.

"Ah." He nodded sagely. "The minister kept you up? Or something else?"

Amina hesitated. She had not told anyone about the letters. It felt too personal, too strange. But Daniel was her mentor, the person who had taught her everything about journalism. If anyone would understand, it was him.

"I found something yesterday," she said. "At a secondhand bookstore. A box of letters."

Daniel raised an eyebrow and pulled up a chair. "Love letters?"

"How did you know?"

"Because you have that look." He took a sip of his coffee. "That's the look of someone who's found a story. A real one. Not the kind that comes in a press release."

Amina smiled. "They were written by a man named Joseph. To a woman named Margaret. In 1998 to 2001. He never sent them."

"Never sent them?" Daniel leaned forward. "Why?"

"I don't know yet. But there are forty-seven letters. And they're... beautiful, Daniel. Painfully beautiful."

"So what's your story? The letters themselves? Or finding the people behind them?"

Amina considered this. "I think I need to find them. Joseph and Margaret. I need to know what happened."

"The journalist's instinct." Daniel nodded approvingly. "Follow it. But be careful, Amina. Love stories from twenty years ago — they're not always what they seem. People change. Memories fade. The truth might not match the poetry."

"I know."

"Do you need time off?"

"I have leave saved up. A week, maybe two."

"Take it." Daniel stood, clapping her on the shoulder. "Go find your painter and your Margaret. And when you come back, write the story. It deserves to be told."

Amina felt a surge of gratitude. "Thank you, Daniel."

"Just promise me one thing."

"What?"

"Don't fall in love with the story." He grinned, but there was a warning in his eyes. "Stories can break your heart just as easily as people can."

He walked away before she could respond.

That afternoon, Amina began her investigation.

She started with St. Mary's Cathedral. A phone call to the parish office confirmed that a wedding had taken place there on October 11, 1998 — a Mr. John Kato and a Miss Margaret Nanyonga.

Margaret Nanyonga.

She wrote the name in her notebook, underlining it twice.

Next, she searched social media. Facebook yielded nothing — there were dozens of Margaret Nanyongas, none of whom matched the description. She tried LinkedIn, Twitter, Instagram. Nothing.

She called a contact at the National Identification and Registration Authority. A favor was called in. Within hours, she had an address.

Margaret Nanyonga Kato was living in Muyenga, a wealthy suburb on the hills overlooking Kampala. She was married to John Kato, a businessman. They had two children, both in university abroad.

Amina stared at the address on her screen. She had found Margaret.

Now she needed to find Joseph.

Chapter 5 — The Missing Painter

Finding Joseph proved to be significantly harder.

Amina searched for "Joseph Mugisha painter Kampala" and found three results. The first was a Facebook page that had not been updated since 2015. The second was an old blog post from 2009, reviewing an art exhibition at the Uganda Museum. The third was an obituary — but it was for a different Joseph Mugisha, a teacher from Gulu.

She called the number listed on the Facebook page. It was disconnected.

She visited the gallery mentioned in the blog post — a small space in the industrial area of Kampala, near the old railway station. The gallery was closed, its windows shuttered, a "For Rent" sign taped to the door.

She asked at neighboring businesses. A man selling phone accessories had been there for three years and had never heard of a Joseph Mugisha. A woman who ran a printing shop nearby had been in the area for a decade but did not recognize the name.

"Try the art school," she suggested. "At Makerere. Many artists come from there."

So Amina drove to Makerere University, navigating the chaos of traffic and the maze of the campus. The Margaret Trowell School of Industrial and Fine Arts was a cluster of buildings surrounded by trees, quiet and contemplative.

She found the department administrator, a woman named Grace who had been at the school for thirty years.

"Joseph Mugisha?" Grace repeated, her brow furrowing. "The name sounds familiar. Give me a moment."

She disappeared into a back room, returning with a heavy ledger. She flipped through the pages, running her finger down columns of names.

"Here," she said finally. "Joseph Mugisha. Graduated 1996. Bachelor of Fine Arts, specialization in painting."

"Do you have any records of where he went after graduation?"

Grace shook her head. "We don't keep track. But..." she paused, thinking. "I remember him. Quiet boy."

Very talented. His final exhibition was extraordinary — landscapes, mostly. But there was one portrait. A woman. He would not sell it. Said it was personal."

Amina's heart quickened. "Do you remember what the woman looked like?"

"Beautiful. Dark skin, kind eyes. She was sitting at a table with a cup of coffee, writing in a notebook."

Margaret. It had to be.

"Do you know where I can find him now?"

Grace thought for a long moment. "There was an old student who stayed in touch. Franco — Franco Wasswa. He runs a gallery in the city. If anyone knows where Joseph is, it might be him."

Franco's Gallery was in the heart of Kampala, a converted house on a tree-lined street in Kololo. The walls were covered with vibrant paintings — abstracts, portraits, landscapes, all by Ugandan artists.

Franco himself was a tall, thin man in his forties, wearing a paint-stained shirt and an easy smile. He

listened to Amina's story without interruption, his expression unreadable.

"Joseph Mugisha," he said when she finished. He said the name like it was a prayer.

"You know him?"

"I knew him." Franco walked to a cabinet in the corner of the gallery and pulled out a bottle of whiskey and two glasses. He poured without asking if she wanted any. "Joseph was my best friend at Makerere. We graduated together. We were going to take over the art world together."

"Was?"

Franco handed her a glass. "Joseph disappeared about ten years ago. Just... vanished. Stopped returning calls. Stopped painting. Left his studio and never came back."

"Do you know why?"

Franco took a long drink. "I think I do. But it's not my story to tell." He looked at her, really looked at her, as if seeing her for the first time. "Why are you looking for him?"

Amina told him about the letters. Franco's eyes widened, then softened.

"He always was writing something," Franco said. "I used to tease him about it. I never knew they were love letters."

"Can you help me find him?"

Franco was silent for a long moment. Then he stood and walked to his desk, pulling out a piece of paper and a pen. He wrote something down and handed it to her.

"This is his last known address. It's outside Jinja, near the lake. I went there once, about eight years ago. He was... not well. He asked me not to come back."

Amina looked at the address. The paper felt heavy in her hands.

"I don't know if he'll want to see you," Franco said. "But if anyone can convince him to talk, maybe it's the woman who's been reading his heart."

Chapter 6 — The Journey to Jinja

The bus from Kampala to Jinja took two hours, but Amina felt like she was traveling to a different world.

The city fell away, replaced by green hills and red-earth roads, villages of mud-brick houses and tin roofs, fields of matoke and sugarcane. The sky seemed bigger here, wider, full of clouds that promised rain but never delivered.

She sat by the window, a notebook open on her lap, the box of letters at her feet. She had read them all now, some of them twice. She knew Joseph's story in fragments — his love for Margaret, his work as a painter, his growing isolation. The last letters were darker, sadder. He had stopped going to the café. He had stopped leaving his studio. He had stopped believing that love was something he deserved.

January 3, 2000

My Dearest Margaret,

I saw you again today. It has been over a year since your wedding, and I still cannot look away. You were in the market with your husband. You were pregnant

— I could see it in the way you walked, the way you held yourself. You were glowing.

I should be happy for you. I am happy for you. But there is a part of me, a selfish part, that still wishes things were different.

I have stopped painting people. I paint landscapes now — empty fields, lonely trees, the lake at sunset. I paint things that do not remind me of what I cannot have.

I wonder if you ever think of me. I wonder if you ever noticed the man at the café who always looked at you. I wonder if you ever knew that someone loved you from afar, completely, hopelessly.

Probably not. And that is how it should be.

J

The bus pulled into Jinja town, and Amina stepped out into the heat. The air was thick with the smell of the Nile, that ancient river that had carved its way through history. She had grown up here, in this town, and it still felt like coming home.

She found a boda boda driver who knew the area and showed him the address Franco had given her. The driver — a wiry man named Isaac — nodded.

"Bujagali," he said. "Near the falls. It is far. Thirty minutes."

"Take me there."

They rode through the town and out into the countryside, past sugar plantations and fishing villages, past children walking home from school in their blue-and-white uniforms. The road turned to dirt, then to a narrow track, and finally they stopped at a gate — rusted, half-open, barely visible behind overgrown bougainvillea.

Isaac pointed. "The house is down there. I will wait."

Amina paid him and stood at the gate, her heart pounding. Beyond it, a path led down toward the lake, lined with mango trees and wildflowers. She could see the roof of a house in the distance, a flash of blue paint through the leaves.

She took a breath.

And she walked.

Chapter 7 — The Meeting

The house was small, painted a faded blue that had once been cheerful. A veranda ran across the front, cluttered with potted plants and drying canvases. The garden was wild — beautiful in its neglect, full of flowers and weeds and the rustling of unseen creatures.

Amina stood at the bottom of the steps, unsure what to do. She could hear music playing from inside — old jazz, the kind her father used to listen to. A saxophone drifted through the open window, melancholy and sweet.

She knocked on the wooden frame of the door.

The music stopped.

Footsteps. Slow, deliberate. And then the door opened.

Joseph Mugisha was not what she had expected.

She had imagined someone older, wearier, broken by years of solitude. But the man who stood before her was striking — tall and lean, with strong features

and eyes that held a surprising gentleness. His hair was streaked with grey, but his face was younger than his years, unlined except for the deep creases around his eyes. He wore a paint-stained shirt and trousers, barefoot, a smear of blue paint on his forearm.

"Yes?" His voice was soft, guarded.

"Mr. Mugisha? Joseph Mugisha?"

"Who is asking?"

"My name is Amina Kintu. I'm a journalist with the Kampala Chronicle."

His expression shuttered. "I am not interested in interviews."

"Please — I didn't come for an interview. I came because..." She faltered. How do you tell a stranger you have read his most private thoughts? "I found something. Something that belongs to you."

She reached into her bag and pulled out the box. She held it out to him.

Joseph looked at the box. For a long moment, he did not move. Then, slowly, he reached out and took it. His hands were trembling.

"Where did you find this?" His voice was barely a whisper.

"A bookstore in Kampala. Mr. Mukasa's shop. It was in a lot he bought from an estate sale."

Joseph opened the box. He lifted the top letter, the one dated March 14, 1998. He did not need to read it — he knew what it said.

"I thought these were gone," he said. "I thought I had burned them."

"You didn't."

"No." He let out a shaky breath. "I tried. But I could not bring myself to do it. I put them in a box and hid them away. And then..." He trailed off.

"Life happened?"

Joseph looked up at her, and there was something raw in his eyes. "Yes. Life happened."

He stepped back, opening the door wider. "I suppose you had better come in."

Chapter 8 — The Studio

The inside of Joseph's house was a testament to a life lived in isolation.

Every surface was covered in art. Canvases leaned against every wall, stacked in corners, hung from nails. Paintings of the lake at different times of day — dawn, noon, sunset, midnight. Paintings of trees and birds and the distant hills. Landscapes of a world observed from a distance.

But among the landscapes, Amina noticed something. Every few canvases, there was a portrait. A woman. The same woman, captured in different moments — reading a book, walking in the rain, laughing with her head thrown back.

Margaret.

"May I?" Amina asked, gesturing toward one of the portraits.

Joseph nodded, watching her.

She walked to the painting. It was of Margaret in a yellow dress, standing in what looked like the Old Taxi

Park, the chaos of the city blurred behind her. She was smiling, holding a yellow umbrella, the rain falling around her like diamonds.

"This is beautiful," Amina said. "I've never seen anything like it."

"Her name was Margaret."

"I know." Amina turned to face him. "I've been reading your letters, Mr. Mugisha. I know everything — how you met her, how you watched her, how you loved her. I know you never sent them."

Joseph's face went pale. He sat down heavily on a wooden stool, his hands clasped in front of him.

"How many?"

"Forty-seven."

He closed his eyes. "I didn't remember it was that many."

"Why didn't you send them?"

Joseph was silent for a long moment. When he spoke, his voice was rough. "Because I was afraid. Because she was engaged to someone else. Because I told myself she deserved better than a struggling painter with more dreams than sense."

"But you kept writing."

"Writing was the only way I could love her without hurting anyone." He looked at his hands. "Words on paper don't cause problems. They don't disrupt lives. They just... exist."

Amina sat down across from him. "Why did you leave Kampala?"

Joseph looked past her, out the window, toward the lake. "I stayed until 2008. I kept painting, kept watching her from a distance. I saw her children grow up. I saw her husband succeed in business. I saw her life take shape, and I was not part of it."

He paused. "Then I heard she was sick. Cancer. She was in treatment for a year. I wanted to go to her. I wanted to tell her everything. But what right did I have to burden her with my confession when she was fighting for her life?"

"She recovered?"

"She did. She is healthy now. But after she got better, I realized I couldn't keep living like that. Loving someone from a distance, hoping for something that would never happen. So I left. I came here, to the lake, and I stopped painting people."

"But you paint her. Still."

"I paint her because I cannot forget her." His voice cracked. "And I do not want to."

Chapter 9 — The Confession

They talked for hours.

Amina told him about herself — her childhood in Jinja, her move to Kampala for university, her career as a journalist. She told him about the rain that had driven her into Mukasa's shop, about the instinct that had made her open the box.

Joseph listened, and then he began to talk.

He told her about his childhood in Gulu, the oldest of five children, the son of a teacher and a seamstress. He told her about discovering art at a young age, drawing pictures in the dirt with a stick, painting on scraps of paper with stolen paint.

He told her about moving to Kampala for university, the first in his family to attend. About discovering the café near the university, where he would sit and sketch. About the day Margaret walked in.

"She was reading a book," he said, a distant smile on his face. "She was sitting by the window, and the light was falling on her just so. I had never seen

anyone so beautiful. I stopped breathing for a moment."

"Why didn't you talk to her?"

"I tried. God, I tried. I rehearsed conversations in my head. I wrote scripts. But every time I got close, I froze. She seemed so... complete. Like she already had everything she needed. And I had nothing to offer."

"You had your art."

"My art was a dream. Dreams don't pay rent." He laughed bitterly. "She married a businessman. A man who could give her stability, security, a future. I was painting pictures that no one bought. What was I supposed to say? 'Love me instead, I can offer you beautiful sunsets on canvas'?"

Amina leaned forward. "You could have said, 'I love you.' That would have been enough."

"Would it?" Joseph met her eyes. "Do you really believe that love without action, without commitment, without a foundation — do you believe that is enough?"

Amina thought about her own life. Her failed relationships, her career that consumed everything, the walls she had built around herself.

"I don't know," she admitted. "I want to believe it is."

The afternoon turned to evening. The light through the window softened, turning gold, then amber, then violet. Joseph made them tea, and they sat on the veranda, watching the sun set over Lake Victoria.

"Why did you come looking for me?" Joseph asked.

"Because the letters deserve to be read by someone. Because your story deserves to be told."

"I am not sure I want it told."

"Then I won't tell it." Amina set down her cup. "I'm not here to expose you or embarrass you. I'm here because... I felt something when I read those letters. A connection. A sadness. A beauty that I wanted to understand."

Joseph was quiet for a long time.

"Will you show me the lake?" Amina asked.

Joseph looked at her, surprised. Then a small smile touched his lips. "If you want."

They walked down to the shore, the water lapping gently at the rocks. The sky was a canvas of orange and purple, the sun a burning coin on the horizon. A fishing boat drifted in the distance, its silhouette black against the fire.

"I haven't shown anyone the lake in years," Joseph said.

"Then I'm honored."

They stood in silence, watching the day end.

Chapter 10 — The Unraveling

Amina stayed in Jinja for three days.

Each morning, she walked from the small guesthouse where she was staying to Joseph's house by the lake. They would drink tea on the veranda, and he would tell her more about his life. Each evening, she would return to her room and write in her notebook, trying to capture everything — the way he spoke, the way he moved, the sadness that lingered in his eyes like smoke.

On the second day, he showed her his studio.

It was a separate building behind the house, a small concrete structure with a corrugated iron roof. Inside, it was chaos — tubes of paint everywhere, brushes soaking in jars of turpentine, canvases in various stages of completion.

But it was the wall that stopped her heart.

The entire back wall was covered in sketches of Margaret. Dozens of them, pinned up like a shrine. Margaret reading. Margaret laughing. Margaret

walking. Margaret asleep. Margaret crying. Margaret in the rain, in the sun, in every kind of light.

"This is where I come when I cannot sleep," Joseph said quietly. "I draw her from memory. I try to capture the details I might be forgetting."

"You're afraid of forgetting her?"

"I'm afraid of losing even this — the memory of her. She was the best thing that never happened to me. If I lose that, what do I have?"

Amina looked at the sketches, at the love that covered every inch of the wall. "You have your art. You have this place. You have the lake."

"Those aren't enough."

"What would be enough?"

Joseph did not answer.

On the third day, Amina made a decision.

"I'm going to find Margaret," she said.

Joseph looked up sharply. "No."

"Joseph — "

"No." His voice was firm. "She doesn't know about me. She doesn't know about the letters. After all these years, I will not walk into her life and upend it with a confession she never asked for."

"Then let me talk to her. As a journalist. I'll say I'm doing a story on love in Kampala, or — "

"She's not stupid. She'll know."

"Maybe that's okay." Amina sat down across from him. "Maybe she deserves to know. Maybe someone loved her so deeply that he wrote her forty-seven letters. Maybe that knowledge might mean something to her."

"What if it ruins her marriage?"

"What if it doesn't? What if she always wondered if there was someone else out there? What if she felt it — that someone was watching her, loving her from afar?"

Joseph shook his head. "You're romanticizing this."

"Maybe I am. But isn't that better than hiding from it?" She reached out and took his hand. "You've been hiding for twenty years, Joseph. Maybe it's time to stop."

He looked at their hands, at her fingers wrapped around his.

"Give me one week," she said. "Let me find her. Let me talk to her. If she doesn't want to know, I'll drop it. I'll write your story as a novel, or I'll burn the letters, or whatever you want. But give me this one chance."

Joseph was silent for a long moment.

"One week," he said finally. "And then, no matter what happens, you let it go."

"One week," she agreed.

Chapter 11 — Margaret Kato

Margaret Kato lived in a house that could have been in a magazine.

It was a white villa on a hill in Muyenga, surrounded by manicured gardens and a high wall. A security guard manned the gate, and a maid answered the door. But the woman who appeared behind the maid was not what Amina had expected.

Margaret was beautiful — that was the first thing. Even in her fifties, she carried herself with grace, her face unlined save for the laugh lines around her eyes. She was wearing a simple green dress, her hair threaded with grey, and she looked at Amina with the calm curiosity of someone who had seen enough of life to be surprised by very little.

"Ms. Kintu? The journalist?"

"Yes. Thank you for seeing me."

Margaret led her into a living room that opened onto a terrace overlooking the city. She gestured for Amina to sit.

"Your message was intriguing," Margaret said, settling into an armchair. "You said you had something that belonged to me."

Amina took a breath. This was the moment.

"I found a box of letters," she said. "In a bookstore. They were written by a man named Joseph Mugisha. They were addressed to you."

Margaret's face went still. Not surprised — still. As if she had been waiting for this moment for years.

"Letters," Margaret repeated.

"Forty-seven of them. Written between 1998 and 2001. He never sent them."

Margaret was silent. She looked out the window, at the city spread below them, at the distant hills.

"May I read one?" she asked.

Amina handed her the first letter. Margaret unfolded it with careful hands, her eyes moving across the page. She read slowly, deliberately, as if savoring every word.

When she finished, she set the letter down gently. Her eyes were wet.

"I knew," she said softly. "I always knew."

"You knew?"

"I felt someone watching me. At the café, in the market. I could never catch anyone, but I knew I was being watched. And I knew..." She paused. "I knew there was someone who loved me. I could feel it. Like a warmth that followed me through the city."

"Did you ever try to find him?"

"No. I was engaged. Then married. I told myself it was my imagination." She touched the letter. "But it wasn't."

Amina waited.

"Tell me about him," Margaret said. "Tell me about Joseph."

Chapter 12 — Two Stories

Amina told her everything.

She told her about the painter who had watched her from across the café, too afraid to speak. About the paintings that covered every wall of his studio. About the lake house in Jinja where he had exiled himself. About the years of silence, the years of love never expressed.

Margaret listened without interruption. When Amina finished, she sat in silence for a long time.

"He never married?" Margaret asked finally.

"No."

"Never loved anyone else?"

"I don't think he ever loved anyone but you."

Margaret closed her eyes. "What a terrible thing. To be loved that much and never know it. To live your whole life with someone carrying that weight for you."

"What would you have done if he had spoken to you? Back then, at the café?"

Margaret was silent for a moment. "I don't know. I was in love with John. I am in love with John. But if Joseph had spoken to me... I would have listened. I would have known him. And maybe I would have loved him too, in some way. The way you love someone who sees you completely."

"Would you like to meet him?"

Margaret's eyes widened. "He's... here? In Kampala?"

"He's in Jinja. But I can arrange a meeting. If you want."

Margaret stood and walked to the terrace railing. The wind caught her hair, and for a moment she looked exactly like the sketches on Joseph's wall — beautiful, distant, untouchable.

"I have a husband," she said. "Children. A life that does not include this man. What good would it do to meet him now?"

"Maybe no good. Maybe it would just be... closure. For both of you."

Margaret turned to face her. "Why are you doing this, Ms. Kintu? This is not a story. This is real life. Real people with real consequences."

Amina met her eyes. "Because I read those letters, and I felt something. And I believe that love — real love, the kind that writes forty-seven letters it never sends — deserves to be acknowledged. Even if it's twenty years too late."

Chapter 13 — The Bridge

Three days later, Amina sat in a café in Kampala, waiting.

She had chosen the place carefully — the same café where Joseph had first seen Margaret, all those years ago. It had changed. It was more modern now, with exposed brick and industrial lighting. But the window by the corner table was the same, and the morning light fell through it the same way.

Joseph arrived first. He was nervous, running his hands through his hair, adjusting his shirt collar repeatedly. He sat down across from her with a heavy exhale.

"I shouldn't be here," he said.

"You should. You need closure."

"I've had twenty years of closure. This is reopening a wound."

"Some wounds need to be reopened to heal properly."

He looked at her, and there was something new in his eyes. Something that might have been hope, or fear, or both.

"And what about you?" he asked. "What happens after this?"

Amina did not know how to answer. In the days since she had found the letters, her life had been consumed by Joseph and Margaret. She had barely thought about her job, her apartment, her future. She had been living inside someone else's story.

"I don't know," she said honestly. "I'll go back to work. Write my articles. Pay my bills."

"That sounds lonely."

"It is."

Before Joseph could respond, the door opened.

Margaret walked in.

She was wearing a yellow dress — the same shade as the one in Joseph's painting. She had chosen it deliberately, Amina realized. She stopped at the entrance, scanning the room, and then her eyes found Joseph.

Time stopped.

They looked at each other across the café, across the twenty years that had separated them. The café seemed to fall away — the other customers, the noise, the morning light. There was only them.

Amina stood up. "I'll give you some privacy."

She walked to the counter and ordered a coffee she did not drink, watching them from a distance. They sat across from each other at that corner table. Margaret was crying. Joseph was holding her hand across the table, his head bowed, his shoulders shaking.

It was not the beginning of a love story.

It was the end of one. And it was beautiful.

Chapter 14 — What Remains

The conversation at the café lasted three hours.

Amina waited at the counter, nursing her coffee, watching from a respectful distance. She was a journalist. She could have taken notes, recorded the moment, turned it into a story that would have readers crying into their morning tea.

But she did not. This was not a story. This was real.

When Joseph and Margaret finally stood up, they embraced at the door. It was a long embrace, the kind that speaks in silence. When they parted, Margaret took his face in her hands and said something Amina could not hear.

Then she walked out.

Joseph stood at the door for a long moment, watching her go. When he turned, his face was wet with tears.

"She forgives me," he said when Amina approached. "She said there was nothing to forgive. She said she is grateful."

"Grateful?"

"For loving her. For never telling her. For keeping her in my heart all these years." He let out a shaky laugh. "She said it is the most beautiful thing anyone has ever done for her."

"Are you okay?"

Joseph looked out the window, at the street where Margaret had disappeared, at the city that held the memory of her.

"I don't know," he said. "I think I might be. Finally."

They walked together through the streets of Kampala, past the shops and the street vendors, past the boda bodas weaving through traffic. The city was alive around them, chaotic and beautiful, the same city where Joseph had fallen in love twenty years ago.

"Do you regret it?" Amina asked. "Loving her? Staying silent?"

Joseph considered the question. "I regret the silence. I regret the fear. But I do not regret the love. How can you regret something that made you feel alive?"

"You can regret the pain it caused."

"Yes." He nodded slowly. "I regret the pain. But pain is the price of love. You cannot have one without the other."

They stopped at the top of a hill, looking down at the city. The Old Taxi Park sprawled below them, a chaos of buses and people and movement. Beyond it, the minarets of the Gaddafi Mosque rose against the sky.

"What happens now?" Amina asked.

"Now, I go back to Jinja. I paint. I live." He looked at her. "What about you?"

"I finish the story. The article. Maybe a book." She paused. "Do you mind if I write it?"

"You came all this way. You found me. You brought me closure." He smiled, and it was genuine. "You have earned the right to tell it."

Chapter 15 — The Writer

Amina went back to work.

She wrote the article over three days, sleeping only a few hours each night. It poured out of her — the story of a painter, a woman, and forty-seven unsent letters. She wrote about the café, the lake, the yellow dress. She wrote about love that had existed in silence, preserved on paper, protected from the world.

When she finished, she filed it to the Chronicle.

Daniel read it in his office and came out wiping his eyes. "This is the best thing you have ever written," he said.

"It's not a story. It's a confession."

"It's a story. And it's going to make people feel something." He paused. "Are you ready for that?"

She was not sure. But she nodded anyway.

The article ran on Sunday. The response was immediate. Letters poured into the Chronicle — from people who had loved from afar, from people who had

been loved and never known, from people who recognized themselves in Joseph and Margaret.

Amina answered every letter. She sat in her apartment in Ntinda, reading stories of love and loss and longing, and she answered them all.

But one letter was different.

It arrived on a Tuesday, in a plain white envelope, no return address. Inside was a single sheet of paper, and on it were written four words:

Thank you. — J.

Chapter 16 — The Return

Two months passed.

Amina's article had been picked up by news outlets across East Africa. She received offers to write a book, to appear on radio shows, to speak at events. She turned most of them down. She told Joseph's story one more time — in a longer, more detailed version that became a feature in the Chronicle's magazine — and then she stopped.

The story had been told. It was time to move on.

But she could not stop thinking about Joseph.

She thought about him when she walked past the café. She thought about him when she saw yellow sunflowers in the market. She thought about him when she sat alone in her apartment at night, the city humming outside her window, the bed too large for one person.

She told herself it was just the story. She had become invested in her subject. It happened to journalists all the time. It would pass.

It did not pass.

Finally, on a Saturday morning, she took the bus to Jinja.

Joseph was painting when she arrived.

He was on the veranda, a canvas on an easel, lost in his work. The lake sparkled behind him, and the morning light was soft and golden. He looked up when he heard her footsteps, and his face broke into a smile that made her heart stop.

"Amina." He set down his brush. "I didn't expect you."

"I know. I should have called."

"No. It's good to see you."

She sat down on the step below him, looking at the painting. It was of a woman — not Margaret, but someone else. A woman with a notebook, her hair falling over her face, her pen hovering over the page.

"Is that... me?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Joseph set down his brush. "Because I cannot stop thinking about you."

The words hung in the air between them, delicate as glass.

"Amina, I have spent twenty years loving someone I could not have. I do not want to spend another twenty years making the same mistake." He knelt in front of her, taking her hands. "I am not a young man. I am not a successful man. I live in a small house by the lake, and I paint pictures that most people will never see. But I am a man who knows how to love. And I know that I am falling in love with you."

Amina could not breathe. "Joseph..."

"You do not have to say anything. I know this is complicated. I know I am part of a story you are trying to finish. But I needed you to know. Because if I learned anything from those letters, it is that silence is a kind of death. And I am tired of being silent."

Chapter 17 — The Choice

Amina walked along the lake shore, alone.

She needed to think, to clear her head. The water lapped at her feet, and the sun was warm on her shoulders, and her mind was a storm of confusion.

She was a journalist. She had found his story, told his story. She was supposed to be objective, professional, detached. She was not supposed to fall in love with the subject of her article.

But she had.

And the question was: what was she going to do about it?

She thought about Daniel's warning — Don't fall in love with the story. She thought about Joseph's letters, written to a woman he had been too afraid to approach. She thought about her own life, her empty apartment, her string of failed relationships, the walls she had built around herself.

She was afraid. She was so afraid.

But she was also tired. Tired of safety. Tired of distance. Tired of writing about other people's lives while her own remained unwritten.

She turned around and walked back to Joseph's house.

He was sitting on the veranda, waiting for her.

"I'm afraid," she said.

"I know. So am I."

"I don't know if this is real. I don't know if I'm confusing the story with my feelings. I don't know if I'm running away from my life or toward something new."

"Neither do I." He stood up, walking toward her. "But I know that when I see you, I feel like painting again. Not landscapes. Not memories. You. The present. The future."

"Joseph — "

"You asked me once what would be enough. What would make my life complete." He took her hand. "I think it might be you."

Amina looked at him — this strange, beautiful man who had spent twenty years loving a woman from a distance, who had written forty-seven letters he never sent, who had lived alone by the lake, painting the ghost of a love that never was.

"I'm not Margaret," she said.

"I know. You are Amina. And I have not painted Margaret since I met you."

She stood there, on the shore of the lake, the water whispering at her feet, the sun warming her skin. She thought about the box of letters. She thought about fate and coincidence and the strange paths that love takes.

Then she made her choice.

Chapter 18 — Letters We Send

Two months later, Amina moved to Jinja.

It was not a decision she made lightly. She resigned from the Chronicle, packed her apartment into boxes, and said goodbye to Daniel and her colleagues. He hugged her at the farewell dinner and whispered in her ear, "I told you not to fall in love with the story."

"I fell in love with the man," she whispered back. "There's a difference."

She moved into Joseph's house by the lake. It was small, and cramped, and full of his paintings and her books. They made room for each other, reorganized the shelves, cleared a corner for her desk.

She still wrote. Articles for freelance publications, a book she was working on — not about Joseph, but about the city she loved, Kampala in all its chaos and beauty. She interviewed street vendors and taxi drivers and market women, documenting the stories that would otherwise be lost.

Joseph painted. He had started painting people again — not just landscapes, not just memories. He painted the fishermen on the lake, the children playing on the shore, the old women selling vegetables at the market. And he painted her.

He painted her in the morning, when she woke up with her hair everywhere. He painted her at her desk, biting her pen, lost in thought. He painted her in the garden, laughing at something he had said. He painted her in the rain, dancing like no one was watching.

And every night, they would sit on the veranda and watch the sun set over the lake, and he would tell her that he was writing new letters now — not letters he would never send, but words he would say out loud.

Chapter 19 — The Exhibition

The exhibition was Franco's idea.

"People need to see his work," he had insisted. "A talent like that should not be hidden in a house by the lake."

Amina had agreed. She had spent weeks convincing Joseph, cajoling, arguing, and finally winning him over. He had protested, made excuses, tried to back out a dozen times. But on the night of the exhibition, when the doors of Franco's Gallery opened, he was standing there in a new shirt, his hands shaking, his eyes full of fear.

"You will be fine," Amina told him, squeezing his hand.

"What if no one comes?"

"A dozen people have already confirmed. Franco said so."

"What if they hate the work?"

"Then we drink the wine and laugh about it."

He laughed despite himself. "You are impossible."

"I am persistent. There is a difference."

The gallery filled. Franco had done his job well — the space was elegant, the lighting perfect, the paintings arranged to tell a story. Joseph's landscapes, his portraits, his studies of light and shadow. And at the center of the main wall, a painting of Amina.

She had not known he was going to display it. When she saw it, she stopped breathing.

She was sitting at her desk, her head bent over a notebook, the morning light streaming through the window. It was her, completely her, captured with such tenderness that she felt tears prick her eyes.

The title card read: The Writer.

By the end of the night, nine paintings had sold.

Joseph was surrounded by people — admirers, critics, potential buyers. He was smiling, laughing, accepting compliments with the dazed look of someone who had forgotten how to receive praise.

Amina watched from across the room, a glass of wine in her hand, a smile on her face.

"You did good," Franco said, appearing at her side.

"He did good. I just pushed."

"He needed pushing." Franco raised his glass. "To the person who finally got him out of his own way."

They clinked glasses.

"Are you staying here tonight?" Franco asked. "In Kampala?"

"No. We're going back to Jinja. Tomorrow morning."

"The lake house?"

"The lake house."

Franco smiled. "I worried about him, you know. For years. After he left Kampala, I thought he would never come back — not to the city, not to the world. I thought he would spend the rest of his life alone with his ghosts."

"And now?"

"Now he has you. And the ghosts are gone." Franco looked at her. "Thank you, Amina."

"I did nothing."

"You loved him. That is everything."

Later that night, when the gallery had emptied and the wine was finished, Amina and Joseph walked through the quiet streets of Kololo. The city was sleeping around them, the air cool and clean.

"I cannot believe nine paintings sold," Joseph said, still in a daze.

"Your art is beautiful. People recognized it."

"I stopped believing in that a long time ago."

"And now?"

He stopped walking and turned to face her. The streetlight cast a golden glow around them.

"Now I believe in many things I had forgotten." He took her hand. "I believe in new beginnings. I believe that some stories take time to find their ending. I believe that a box of unsent letters can change a life."

"It changed mine," Amina said.

"Has it? For the better?"

She reached up and touched his face, tracing the lines that worry and time had carved there. "I found you," she said. "A man who loved so deeply that he could not stop writing. A man who never stopped believing in love, even when he had given up on

himself. You taught me that love is not about timing, or circumstance, or convenience. It is about saying yes, even when you are afraid. It is about writing the letter and sending it."

"I love you, Amina."

"I love you too, Joseph."

They stood there, in the street, under the Kampala sky, and they held each other. Twenty years of unsent letters had led to this — a moment, real and imperfect and absolutely right.

Chapter 20 — Epilogue: The Letters We Send

A year later

The box sat on the table in the middle of the room.

It was the same box Amina had found in Mukasa's bookstore — dark wood, brass latch, worn smooth by time. Joseph had asked her to bring it. He had something he wanted to do.

They stood on the veranda of the lake house, the morning sun warm on their faces. The box was open on the table, the letters inside, still tied with red ribbon.

"I have been carrying these for twenty years," Joseph said. "They started as a confession, became a burden, and ended as... I do not know what."

"A gift," Amina said. "They were always a gift. Even if she never read them."

"Yes." He smiled. "I think I know that now."

He reached into the box and pulled out the top letter — the first one, written in March 1998. He unfolded it and read the opening lines.

"My Dearest M, I am writing this letter knowing I will never send it."

He looked up at the lake, at the water that had witnessed his solitude, his healing, his new beginning.

"I am done with letters I never send," he said.

He took a lighter from his pocket and held it to the corner of the paper.

"Joseph — " Amina started.

He shook his head. "I do not need them anymore. I have you. I have words I speak instead of words I write. I have a life that is real."

He let the flame catch. The paper curled and blackened, the ink dissolving, the words disappearing. He held it until the fire reached his fingers, then dropped it into a metal bowl.

Letter by letter, he burned them.

The smoke rose over the lake, carrying twenty years of love, grief, longing, hope. And when the last letter was ash, Joseph turned to Amina.

"Now," he said, "I will write you new letters. And I will send every single one."

Later that afternoon, Amina sat at her desk, a fresh notebook open before her. She picked up her pen and began to write.

Not an article. Not a story for the newspaper. A letter.

Dear Joseph,

I have been thinking about how love finds us. Not the way we expect — not with grand gestures or perfect timing, but quietly, like the rain that falls on Kampala in November. Unexpected. Necessary. Renewing.

I found your letters in a dusty bookstore, and they led me to you. And now I am writing my own — a letter I will give you tonight, when you come back from the market. A letter I will see you read.

I love you.

That is all.

Yours, Amina

She folded the paper and slipped it into an envelope. She wrote his name on the front and set it on the table, where he would find it.

Then she walked outside to sit on the veranda and watch the sun set over the lake, the same lake that had witnessed Joseph's loneliest years, now witnessing the beginning of something new.

Some letters are never sent.

Some letters wait twenty years to be read.

And some letters — the best ones — are written, sealed, and given to the person you love, who is waiting for you at home.

— The End —

About the Author

Walusimbi Leon (SGSS) is a writer and storyteller based in Kampala, Uganda. *Letters I Never Sent* is his first novel — a meditation on love, timing, and the courage it takes to speak the words we carry in our hearts.

"To everyone who has ever loved from a distance —
this is for you."

— THE END —